Could the Popular Vote Choose the Next President?

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The **midterm** elections may change how Americans pick a president. Right now, candidates win by collecting **Electoral College** votes from each state. That makes them focus on a few **swing states**. A deal called the National Popular Vote **Interstate Compact** could change that. States that join agree to give their **Electoral College** votes to the candidate who wins the most votes in the whole country. Eighteen states have already joined. Together, they hold 222 **Electoral College** votes. Once the states in the deal add up to 270, the candidate with the most votes **nationwide** would win. After the recent elections, Democrats now fully control six more states: Arizona, Michigan, Minnesota, Nevada, Pennsylvania, and Wisconsin. Some leaders are hopeful. Wisconsin's new governor, David Crowley, said, 'We can do away with it.' Pennsylvania's governor, Josh Shapiro, said the national popular vote 'makes sense.' But not everyone agrees. Republicans say the plan would weaken the voice of smaller states. **Legal challenges** are almost certain, and the plan could end up before the Supreme Court.

Word Treasure

Electoral College -- The Electoral College is the group of votes each state gives to pick the president.

Interstate Compact -- A compact is a formal deal between states.

swing states -- Swing states are states where either side could win.

nationwide -- Nationwide means across the whole country.

midterm -- Midterm elections are elections held in the middle of a president's term.

Legal challenges -- A legal challenge is when someone asks a court to decide if a plan is allowed.

Background you need

In the United States, the president is picked by collecting Electoral College votes from each state, not just by counting all the votes in the country.

A deal called the National Popular Vote Interstate Compact would change that: states that join would give their votes to the candidate who wins the most votes nationwide.

The idea became popular after elections where the winner of the Electoral College lost the national popular vote, but it would face legal challenges.

Break it down

WHO: Democratic governors and lawmakers, including David Crowley of Wisconsin and Josh Shapiro of Pennsylvania, and Republican critics.

WHAT: A deal called the National Popular Vote Interstate Compact could make the national popular vote decide who becomes president.

WHERE: Across the United States, in states such as Arizona, Michigan, Minnesota, Nevada, Pennsylvania, and Wisconsin.

WHY: Because the recent elections gave Democrats full control of six more states, opening the door for more states to join the deal.

Why it matters

How the president is chosen decides which voters candidates pay attention to, and that shapes the country you will grow up in.

Test what you remember

1. What is the National Popular Vote Interstate Compact?

- (A) A rule that bans swing states
- (B) A new way to count votes in one state
- (C) A plan to let governors pick the president
- (D) A deal where states give their Electoral College votes to the national popular vote winner

2. How many states have already joined the deal?

- (A) Eighteen
- (B) Two hundred twenty-two
- (C) Six
- (D) Two hundred seventy

3. How many Electoral College votes do the joined states hold together?

- (A) 222
- (B) 71
- (C) 270
- (D) 18

4. What number must the states in the deal add up to?

- (A) 100
- (B) 270
- (C) 222
- (D) 50

5. Which six states do Democrats now fully control?

- (A) California, New York, Illinois, Oregon, Washington, and Massachusetts
- (B) Arizona, Michigan, Minnesota, Nevada, Pennsylvania, and Ohio
- (C) Texas, Florida, Ohio, Georgia, North Carolina, and Virginia
- (D) Arizona, Michigan, Minnesota, Nevada, Pennsylvania, and Wisconsin

6. What did David Crowley say about the Electoral College?

- (A) 'Smaller states need more votes'
- (B) 'We can do away with it'
- (C) 'The plan is unfair'
- (D) 'It should never change'

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: A 3: A 4: B 5: D 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Supporters like David Crowley and Josh Shapiro: Say the national popular vote makes sense and the Electoral College can be done away with.

2. Republican critics: Say the plan would weaken the voice of smaller states.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):